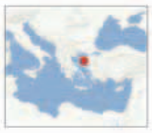
LATER OTTOMAN BATTLES

THE OTTOMAN EMPIRE declined during the 18th and 19th centuries as it found itself unable to match the technological and organizational progress made by the European powers. Although still capable of defeating the similarly stagnant Venetians in the Mediterranean, the Turkish Navy had its weaknesses exposed during the wars with the expanding Russian Empire in 1768–74 and 1787–91. With the aid of foreign naval advisers, the Russians achieved a level of fighting efficiency and tactical flair far superior to that of the timidly led Ottoman fleet. Russian warships entered the Mediterranean for the first time to defeat the Turks at Chesma in 1770, and got the better of a series of engagements in the Black Sea, culminating in the victory at Tendra in 1790—despite simultaneously fighting Sweden in the Baltic. The one-sided battle of Navarino in 1827, the last fleet engagement of the age of sail, completed the humiliation of the once proud Turkish navy. The Ottomans continued to spend heavily on warships—in 1875 they had the third largest navy in the world—but they never again fought a battle at sea.

RUSSO-TURKISH WAR

CHESMA



Date July 5–7, 1770
Forces Russians: 9 ships of the line; Ottomans: c.20 ships of the line
Losses Russians: 1 ship of the line; Ottomans: c.19 ships of the line
Location Near island of Chios, Aegean

After war broke out between Imperial Russia and Ottoman Turkey in 1768, two squadrons of Russian warships were sent from the Baltic Sea to the Mediterranean, under the command respectively of Admiral Grigory Spiridov and Rear Admiral John Elphinston, one of many British naval officers serving with the Russian navy. Count Alexsei Girgoryevich Orlov, an important figure at court, was given overall control of the naval force. His ultimate mission was to encourage a Greek revolt against Turkish rule.

On July 5, 1770, the two Russian squadrons found a Turkish fleet in Chesma Bay between the island of Chios and the Anatolian mainland. Lacking confidence in their seamanship, the Turks were anchored in two lines to form a floating battery, the ships in the second line positioned to fire through the gaps in the first. Although outnumbered, the Russian ships sailed in to attack. Spiridov's flagship *Yevstafy* closely engaged the Turkish flagship *Real Mustafa*, setting its mast on fire. Unfortunately for the Russians the blazing mast fell onto the *Yevstafy* and both ships were destroyed in the ensuing conflagration. Admiral Spiridov escaped, but more than 500 Russian sailors were killed.

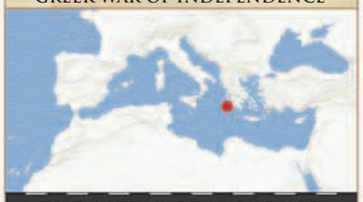
After this engagement the Turkish fleet withdrew further into the bay, which was crowded with the ships of the line and a host of frigates, xebecs, galleys, and other smaller craft. The Russian and British officers decided to attempt a night attack. A force of four ships of the line, two frigates, a bomb boat, and four fireships was put under the command of Scottish-born commodore Samuel Greig. The force advanced into the bay at around midnight while other ships targeted shore batteries and gave supporting fire.

The mortars of the bomb boat and broadsides of the ships of the line soon took their toll and by the time the fireships were sent in, several Turkish ships of the line were destroyed or on fire. Soon the bay was a mass of blazing ships, many set alight by explosions on board their neighbors. The entire Ottoman fleet at Chesma was destroyed except for one 60-gun ship and five galleys captured by the Russians. The battle left the Russian navy in command of the Aegean Sea.



Destruction of the Ottoman fleet
Turkish sailors abandon their burning ships during the Russian attack on the Ottoman fleet at Chesma.

GREEK WAR OF INDEPENDENCE



THE BATTLE OF NAVARINO

Date	October 20, 1827
Location	Off west coast of the Peloponnese
Result	British, French, and Russian victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN, FRANCE, RUSSIA	OTTOMAN EMPIRE, EGYPT

COMMANDERS

Edward Codrington	Ibrahim Pasha

FORCES

Ships: 22 ships including 10 ships of the line	**Ships:** 78 ships including 3 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: 181 **Ships:** none	**Men:** c.3,000 **Ships:** 70 ships

Victory for the Great Powers
British, French, and Russian ships attack the Ottoman-Egyptian fleet, anchored three-deep in a crescent formation at Navarino.



RUSSO-TURKISH WAR

TENDRA



Date September 8–9, 1790
Forces Russians: 10 ships of the line, 6 frigates; Ottomans: 14 ships of the line, 8 frigates
Losses Russians: none; Ottomans: 2 ships of the line
Location Off Tendra Island, Black Sea

During the Russo-Turkish War of 1787–91, Russia found an inspired naval commander in Rear Admiral Fyodor Fyodorovich Ushakov, who distinguished himself in victories at Fidonisi in 1788 and the Kerch Strait in July 1790. In September 1790 Ushakov surprised the Turkish fleet at anchor off Tendra Island in the Black Sea. He immediately attacked their rear, seizing the tactical initiative. The Ottomans had a clear numerical advantage, which Ushakov countered by including three frigates in his line of battle and positioning three other frigates alongside his ships in the van, to block any Turkish effort to double the line. The Russians had the better of the exchange of broadsides and the Turks, whose ships were copper-bottomed, used their superior speed to disengage. Ushakov pursued vigorously, inflicting significant damage on a number of the departing Turkish ships.

The following day Ushakov caught up with two ships of the line. One was easily captured but the other ship, the flagship of Admiral Said Bey, held out for hours despite being surrounded by Russian guns. The ship eventually caught fire and exploded before most of the 800 crew could be taken off. This victory, costing the Ottomans 1,400 casualties and 733 prisoners, gave the Russians command of the Black Sea which was confirmed by a victory at Kaliakria the following year.